

Software Project Proposal

StaffQuest: A Gamified Training and Motivation System for Restaurant Employees

Lance Page

INF 651: Software Engineering Project

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Problem Statement

The restaurant industry experiences one of the highest turnover rates in the workforce. Many employees, especially new hires, struggle to stay engaged during training and often feel disconnected from team performance goals. Traditional onboarding relies on repetitive manuals or short, one-time orientations that fail to sustain motivation. This leads to inconsistent service quality, slower onboarding, and increased costs for retraining.

The core problem is that restaurants lack an engaging, structured system to motivate, train, and retain employees in a way that feels rewarding and interactive. Employees need a way to learn effectively, track their progress, and feel recognized for their effort.

Motivation and Background

Working in food service requires speed, accuracy, and strong teamwork. However, many employees see training as a chore rather than a challenge to improve. Younger generations entering the workforce, many of whom grew up playing games, are familiar with systems that use progress bars, rewards, and challenges to maintain engagement.

By drawing inspiration from gaming principles, it is possible to transform training into something more interactive, enjoyable, and measurable. This approach can shift the mindset from 'just doing a job' to 'leveling up in a team-based experience.' This would also appeal to managers seeking better ways to measure performance beyond subjective evaluation.

Proposed Solution (Conceptual)

StaffQuest proposes a gamified employee engagement and training platform designed for restaurant teams. Rather than reading static manuals or completing checklists, employees would progress through themed 'quests' and 'missions' that simulate real-world scenarios such as taking orders accurately, cleaning efficiently, or managing customer complaints with professionalism.

Each completed task awards experience points (XP), badges, or team rewards, encouraging friendly competition and collaboration. Managers can track progress through a simple dashboard that highlights employee strengths and areas for improvement. The goal is to make learning active, measurable, and rewarding.

Expected Benefits and Value

- Employee Engagement: Encourages active participation in training through interactive challenges and visible progress.
- Consistency: Standardizes the onboarding process across shifts and roles.
- Retention: Reduces turnover by making work feel purposeful and rewarding.
- Team Cohesion: Promotes cooperation through shared goals, team quests, and recognition systems.
- Management Insight: Offers clear visibility into employee growth and readiness.

By introducing game-based learning and recognition, StaffQuest helps bridge the gap between management expectations and employee motivation, improving both workplace morale and service quality.

Potential for Publication or Future Work

This project presents potential for academic research in gamification, workplace motivation, and human-computer interaction. Findings from its implementation could be published in studies focused on employee training systems, behavioral psychology in workforce management, or the design of digital learning environments.

Future versions could expand into other industries beyond restaurants, such as retail, hospitality, or logistics, where similar engagement challenges exist.

Conclusion

StaffQuest aims to reimagine employee training in the restaurant industry by applying game design principles to real-world workplace challenges. By transforming ordinary tasks into engaging missions, the system empowers employees to take pride in learning, fosters teamwork, and ultimately enhances the quality of service delivered to customers.

This project embodies a modern, human-centered approach to improving employee experience, where success feels like leveling up, not clocking in.